

Assessment Authenticity Checklist

A Practical Checklist for Designing AI-Resilient Assessments that Preserve Authentic Student Learning

Version 1.0

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Citation

Asghar, J. (2026). *Assessment Authenticity Checklist: A Practical Checklist for Designing AI-Resilient Assessments that Preserve Authentic Student Learning* (Version 1.0). AI Governance Framework Series. Higher Colleges of Technology.

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About this Framework

The **Assessment Authenticity Checklist** provides a practical framework for designing authentic assessments that continue to generate credible evidence of student learning in the age of generative artificial intelligence. Rather than focusing on detecting AI use after

effective assessment has been completed, the checklist encourages educators to strengthen the assessment design so that meaningful intellectual engagement remains visible throughout the learning process.

Building upon the principles of **Epistemic Responsibility** and **Functional Limitation** introduced in *From Assistance to Authorship*, the checklist supports reflective assessment design by helping educators evaluate whether assessments process continue to measure the knowledge, judgement, reasoning, and disciplinary capabilities they are intended to assess.

The checklist is intended to support lecturers, programme leaders, assessment designers, curriculum developers, and quality assurance teams during assessment design, review, moderation, and programme enhancement. It complements the wider AI Governance Framework Series by providing practical guidance for strengthening authentic assessment while recognising that responsible AI use may legitimately support learning.

Executive Summary

Generative artificial intelligence has fundamentally changed how students complete assessments. Traditional assessment design often assumed that producing written work provided sufficient evidence of learning. AI challenges that assumption by enabling students to generate coherent academic text with relatively little independent intellectual effort.

The response should not be to prohibit AI universally. Instead, assessments should be designed so that authentic intellectual engagement remains visible regardless of whether AI is available.

The Assessment Authenticity Checklist provides a practical framework for evaluating whether assessments continue to measure the knowledge, skills, judgement, and disciplinary reasoning that they were intended to assess.

Rather than functioning as an audit instrument, the checklist supports reflective assessment design. It encourages educators to consider whether students are required to demonstrate meaningful intellectual ownership throughout the assessment process while recognising that responsible AI use may form part of contemporary academic practice.

The checklist complements *From Assistance to Authorship* by operationalising the principles of Epistemic Responsibility and Functional Limitation during assessment design.

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1. Introduction

Assessment has always been more than a mechanism for assigning grades. It communicates what universities value, shapes how students learn, and provides evidence that graduates have achieved defined learning outcomes.

Generative AI has altered this relationship.

Many assessment formats developed before the widespread availability of AI assumed that the final written submission represented the student's own intellectual work. Today, that assumption cannot always be made without additional consideration.

The challenge is not simply technological.

It is educational.

If AI can perform substantial aspects of the intellectual work that an assessment is intended to evaluate, assessment design rather than student behaviour becomes the primary issue.

The Assessment Authenticity Checklist therefore shifts attention away from detecting AI use and towards designing assessments that make learning visible.

2. What Is Assessment Authenticity?

Within this framework, authenticity does not refer simply to real-world tasks or workplace simulation.

Instead, assessment authenticity refers to the extent to which an assessment provides credible evidence that the submitted work reflects the student's own intellectual engagement with the intended learning outcomes.

Authentic assessment therefore demonstrates four characteristics:

- meaningful intellectual ownership;
- alignment with intended learning outcomes;
- visible evidence of reasoning and judgement;
- appropriate integration of AI where educationally justified.

Authenticity is strengthened when educators can confidently determine what students know, understand, and are able to do.



Figure 1. Assessment Authenticity Checklist.

A practical framework for reviewing assessment design to determine whether learning outcomes, intellectual ownership, authentic evidence, transparency, and appropriate AI integration are sufficiently represented to provide credible evidence of student learning.

3. The Six Dimensions of Assessment Authenticity

The checklist is organised around six dimensions that influence authentic learning within AI-supported assessment.

1. Learning Outcome Alignment

The assessment directly evaluates the knowledge, skills, and capabilities specified within the learning outcomes.

Questions:

- What capability is actually being assessed?
 - Could AI perform this capability instead of the student?
 - Does the assessment still measure the intended outcome?
-

2. Intellectual Ownership

Students should demonstrate independent reasoning throughout the assessment.

Questions:

- Where is the student's thinking visible?
 - Which intellectual decisions remain attributable to the student?
 - Does the assessment require explanation or justification?
-

3. Authentic Evidence

The assessment should generate multiple forms of evidence supporting learning.

Possible evidence includes:

- proposals;
- annotated reading;

- drafts;
 - reflective commentary;
 - oral discussion;
 - revision history;
 - process documentation.
-

4. Appropriate AI Integration

Assessment should distinguish between supportive AI use and intellectual substitution.

Questions:

- Which AI uses are educationally appropriate?
 - Which would undermine the learning outcomes?
 - Are expectations communicated clearly?
-

5. Transparency

Students should understand:

- disclosure expectations;
- permitted AI use;
- prohibited practices;
- assessment purpose.

Clear expectations reduce misunderstanding.

6. Educational Value

The assessment should promote meaningful learning rather than merely discourage misconduct.

Questions:

- Does the assessment encourage critical thinking?

- Does it reward judgement?
- Does it promote reflection?
- Does it remain educationally valuable if AI is available?

4. The Assessment Authenticity Checklist

The following checklist is intended for use during assessment design and review.

Dimension	Yes	Partly	No
Learning outcomes are clearly assessed.	☐	☐	☐
Students must demonstrate independent reasoning.	☐	☐	☐
Assessment generates authentic evidence of learning.	☐	☐	☐
Appropriate AI use is clearly defined.	☐	☐	☐
Disclosure expectations are explained.	☐	☐	☐
Students explain important decisions.	☐	☐	☐
Assessment values judgement over reproduction.	☐	☐	☐
Assessment includes opportunities for reflection.	☐	☐	☐
Assessment remains meaningful if AI is available.	☐	☐	☐
Assessment supports fair evaluation.	☐	☐	☐

5. Applying the Checklist

The checklist is intended to support assessment design before an assessment is delivered. It may also be used during module review, programme validation, moderation, or curriculum redesign.

The checklist should not be interpreted as a scoring instrument. Its purpose is to stimulate professional reflection and encourage evidence-informed assessment decisions.

Educators are encouraged to work through each dimension sequentially, beginning with learning outcomes rather than technology.

The central question throughout is:

Does this assessment provide credible evidence of the student's own intellectual achievement?

If the answer is uncertain, assessment redesign should be considered before additional academic integrity procedures are introduced.

6. Worked Examples

Case Study 1 – Traditional Essay

Assessment

A 2,500-word essay submitted at the end of the semester.

Checklist Review

Dimension	Evaluation
Learning outcome alignment	Strong
Intellectual ownership	Moderate
Authentic evidence	Weak
Appropriate AI integration	Weak
Transparency	Weak
Educational value	Moderate

Commentary

The essay assesses disciplinary knowledge effectively but provides limited evidence of how the work developed. Because only the final product is submitted, distinguishing between genuine intellectual engagement and AI-assisted production may be difficult.

Suggested Enhancement

Require:

- a proposal;

- annotated bibliography;
- reflective commentary;
- brief oral discussion.

These additions strengthen evidence of learning without fundamentally changing the assessment.

Case Study 2 – Research Project

Assessment

Students complete a semester-long research investigation including proposal, literature review, data collection, analysis, presentation, and reflective commentary.

Checklist Review

Dimension	Evaluation
Learning outcome alignment	Strong
Intellectual ownership	Strong
Authentic evidence	Strong
Appropriate AI integration	Strong
Transparency	Strong
Educational value	Strong

Commentary

The assessment naturally generates multiple forms of evidence demonstrating intellectual development. AI may legitimately support language refinement while leaving disciplinary reasoning clearly attributable to the student.

Case Study 3 – Reflective Portfolio

Students document their learning journey throughout the semester.

Checklist Review

Strengths include:

- iterative development;
- visible decision-making;
- personal reflection;
- multiple assessment artefacts.

Potential improvement:

Require students to explain how AI influenced particular stages of their learning process where appropriate.

7. Common Assessment Design Weaknesses

Generative AI exposes weaknesses that have often existed within assessment design but were previously less visible.

The following characteristics increase the likelihood that AI may substitute for rather than support student learning.

Assessing Product Rather than Process

Where only the final submission is evaluated, educators have limited evidence regarding how learning developed.

Over-Reliance on Generic Tasks

Assignments that ask students to describe, summarise, or explain well-established knowledge can often be completed effectively by AI systems.

Limited Contextualisation

Tasks lacking local context, authentic datasets, professional application, or discipline-specific decision-making are generally easier for AI to complete.

Unclear Expectations

Students frequently report uncertainty regarding:

- acceptable AI use;
- disclosure;
- collaboration;
- assessment purpose.

Ambiguity increases inconsistency rather than integrity.

Assessment of Writing Instead of Thinking

Well-written assignments do not necessarily demonstrate deep understanding.

Assessment should therefore value:

- reasoning;
 - judgement;
 - interpretation;
 - justification;
 - reflection.
-

8. Redesign Strategies

Assessment rarely requires complete replacement.

Often, relatively small modifications substantially improve authenticity.

Examples include:

Instead of

Submit one final essay.

Consider

Proposal

↓

Annotated bibliography

↓

Draft

↓

Final submission

↓

Reflective commentary

Instead of

Summarise literature.

Consider

Evaluate conflicting perspectives.

Instead of

Describe a theory.

Consider

Apply the theory to a novel professional problem.

Instead of

Write a report.

Consider

Write the report and explain three important decisions made during its preparation.

Thoughtful assessment redesign frequently provides greater educational benefit than introducing additional AI detection measures alone.

9. Programme Review Checklist

Assessment authenticity should be considered across programmes rather than individual modules alone.

Programme teams should ask:

- ☐ Do assessments collectively evaluate all intended graduate capabilities?
- ☐ Are AI expectations consistent?
- ☐ Are students receiving contradictory guidance?
- ☐ Is authentic evidence generated across the programme?
- ☐ Are assessments becoming progressively more intellectually demanding?
- ☐ Are moderation decisions consistent?
- ☐ Is assessment redesign informed by evidence?

Programme-level coherence strengthens institutional consistency.

10. Guidance for Assessment Designers

When designing new assessments, consider the following sequence.

Step 1

Identify the capability to be assessed.

Step 2

Determine whether AI may legitimately support that capability.

Step 3

Identify evidence demonstrating authentic learning.

Step 4

Communicate AI expectations clearly.

Step 5

Determine whether additional evidence such as reflection or oral verification is educationally appropriate.

Step 6

Review assessment after implementation.

Assessment design should remain iterative rather than static.

Step 7

Evaluate assessment evidence after marking to identify opportunities for future enhancement.

11. Relationship with the Companion Framework Suite

The Assessment Authenticity Checklist operationalises the principles of **Epistemic Responsibility** and **Functional Limitation** during assessment design.

Within the **AI-Integrated Assessment Integrity Lifecycle**, the checklist primarily supports:

Framework	Contribution
From Assistance to Authorship	Conceptual foundation
AI-Integrated Assessment Integrity Lifecycle	Assessment implementation
AI Disclosure Framework	Transparency
Oral Verification Toolkit	Verification of learning
AI Risk-Level Matrix	Educational risk evaluation
Institutional AI Governance Guide	Institution-wide implementation

Together, these frameworks promote assessment systems that preserve meaningful evidence of student learning while recognising responsible AI use.

12. Limitations

The checklist supports reflective assessment design rather than providing a universal quality standard.

Different disciplines require different forms of evidence, and institutional contexts vary considerably.

Accordingly, educators should adapt the checklist while preserving its underlying principles.

The checklist is conceptual and practice-informed. It has not yet undergone formal empirical validation as a standardised assessment design instrument.

13. Conclusion

Authentic assessment has never been defined solely by the absence of technology.

Rather, it depends upon confidence that students have demonstrated the capabilities their qualifications represent.

Generative AI has made this challenge more visible but has not altered its educational purpose.

The Assessment Authenticity Checklist encourages educators to move beyond questions of AI detection and towards assessment designs that make intellectual engagement visible throughout the learning process.

When implemented thoughtfully, authentic assessment supports responsible AI integration while preserving confidence in student achievement, academic standards, and institutional credibility.

Framework Status

Framework type: Assessment design framework

Development status: Conceptual and practice-informed

Validation status: This checklist is conceptual and practice-informed and has not yet undergone formal empirical validation as a standardised assessment design instrument.

Primary users

- Lecturers
- Assessment designers
- Programme leaders
- Curriculum developers
- External examiners
- Quality assurance teams

Companion frameworks

- *From Assistance to Authorship*
- *AI-Integrated Assessment Integrity Lifecycle*
- *AI Disclosure Framework*
- *Oral Verification Toolkit*
- *AI Risk-Level Matrix*
- *Institutional AI Governance Guide for Assessment Integrity*

14. Version History

Version	Date	Description
1.0	July 2026	Initial public release
